CRISIS STABILIZATION ROADMAP

Where to start when it feels like everything at once

A short guide for right now — not forever.

A note on what this is:
This is general education, not personalized legal, tax, or financial advice for your specific situation. For anything specific to you, loop in a licensed professional.

You're trying to solve three problems at the same time — the debt, the cash flow, and not knowing where to start. That's not a character flaw. That's just what panic does when real income disappears. You don't have to fix everything this week.

The Three Questions

Not to diagnose you — to figure out where you actually start. Answer honestly, in your own words.

1

Is the income loss temporary or permanent?

A job that's coming back in a few months calls for a different plan than income that's gone for good. If it's temporary, your focus is bridging the gap. If it's permanent, your focus shifts to rebuilding around a new normal — which is a longer, steadier process, not a race. If the loss was a job, filing for unemployment insurance is an early step — the Guide shows where.

My answer:

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2

Are you current on housing and essential bills?

Rent or mortgage, utilities, food. If you're behind here, this is the fire to put out first — everything else, including debt strategy, waits a beat. If you're current, you have more room to plan before reacting. The Guide's housing and utilities sections tell you who to call.

My answer:

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3

What's causing you the most stress right now — the debt itself, the monthly cash flow, or not knowing where to start?

These are three different problems and they don't get solved the same way. Naming which one is loudest tells you where to start in the Crisis Resource Guide: the debt, start with “If Debt Collectors Are Calling”; the cash flow, start with “Ask for Time” and “Benefits Worth Applying For”; not knowing where to start, start with the Today / This Week / This Month sort.

My answer:

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The Order That Actually Works

First, stabilize. Then, rebuild. Eventually, grow. We don't try to solve everything at once.

Stabilize	Steady the cash flow so you're not white-knuckling every week. This comes before any debt payoff plan or savings plan. The Guide's "Ask for Time" and "Benefits Worth Applying For" sections are your stabilizing tools.
Rebuild	Once you're stable, the debt strategy and the savings cushion get built — on solid ground instead of shaky ground.
Grow	New income streams and longer-term goals come last. Not because they don't matter — because they're what actually sticks once the foundation holds.

If You Need Help Right Now

This Roadmap is the starting point — the Crisis Resource Guide is the next step. It covers how to ask lenders and creditors for time, rental and mortgage help, utility assistance, benefits worth applying for, help through your school, church, or library, plus hotline numbers and free professional resources. If your safety is at risk right now, that comes before anything else — the Guide has those numbers on its first page.

This Isn't Forever

An emergency is not a life sentence, and it isn't a reflection of who you are with money. Most people who feel like this today won't feel like this in six months — especially once the most urgent piece is handled.

When you're in a steadier place and want to do the deeper work, there's a free weekly community called the Long Money Circle. No pressure, no cost — just a place to keep going when you're ready.

You're going to be okay. Let's get through today first.